in pressing Tehran to accept the JCPOA and was now developing important links with Iran. Revival of work on the Chabahar project was, in effect, a product of the US's own policies. The Chabahar project was important to India for a number of reasons. Given China's close cooperation with Pakistan and the China Pakistan Economic Corridor, India needed to develop its own transportation links to Central Asia, including Afghanistan. India could not and would not sacrifice these core interests. Indian representatives could also argue that containing the development of China–Iran ties was an interest shared by New Delhi and Washington, and the United States should not push Iran into alignment with China. Eventually the United States granted India and China six-month waivers, giving both a pass for not cutting purchases of Iranian oil.[24] In effect, US withdrawal from the JCPOA and demand that countries re-impose severe cuts in purchase of Iranian oil produced common Indian and Chinese interests in resisting US demands.

Greater uncertainty regarding the course of US policy under Donald Trump also nudged New Delhi and Beijing closer together. For New Delhi, the weakness of US support during the crisis at Doklam on the Sino–Indian border during 2017 came as a shock. Trump said nothing about the confrontation, the most severe border confrontation since 1987, while the US State Department blandly called for peaceful resolution via negotiations. American lassitude in the midst of severe India–China confrontation increased Indian awareness that it might find itself in a fight with China without strong US support. An Indian push to reduce tension with China was the result. For Beijing, the trade war against China launched by the Trump administration pushed it to seek more economic and political partners to make up for losses inflicted by Washington. Expansion of economic ties with India, a major economy, hedged against a possible collapse of Sino–US trade. In effect, Trump's policies